

The ACT: The Complete Test Guide

The enhanced ACT explained section by section, the optional Science and Writing tests, a 12-week plan, the best free resources, and 10 hard practice questions.

Hi, I'm **Pigo!** I'll drop tips all through this guide.



2:05

hours for the core test
35 + 50 + 40 minutes

131

English, Math and Reading
questions (+40 Science)

1-36

Composite = average of
English, Math, Reading

19.4

average Composite,
class of 2025

INSIDE THIS GUIDE

01	The test at a glance	2	07	Your 12-week study roadmap	8
02	English section	3	08	10 practice questions	9
03	Math section	4	09	Answer key & explanations	10
04	Reading section	5	10	Scores & 2026–27 test dates	11
05	Science & Writing (optional)	6	11	Free resources & test-day checklist	12
06	10 traps that cost points	7			

01 THE TEST AT A GLANCE

Three core sections, two optional

The enhanced ACT is shorter than the old test and gives you more time per question. Your Composite is the average of English, Math and Reading. Science and Writing are optional add-ons.

50 Q English · 35 min	45 Q Math · 50 min	36 Q Reading · 40 min	40 Q Science · optional	Essay Writing · optional
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Test structure

Section	Questions & timing	What you do
English	50 questions 35 min · 1–36	Edit passages for punctuation, grammar, word choice, organization and style. Four choices per question, including NO CHANGE.
Math	45 questions 50 min · 1–36	Pre-algebra through basic trigonometry. A permitted calculator is allowed on every question, and each question now has four choices instead of five.
Reading	36 questions 40 min · 1–36	Passages from fiction, social science, the humanities and natural science, including a paired-passage set. Questions test main ideas, details, author's craft and comparisons.
Science optional	40 questions 40 min · 1–36	Interpret graphs, tables and experiments. Combined with Math into a STEM score . Does not count toward the Composite.
Writing optional	1 essay 40 min · 2–12	Take a position on an issue and weigh it against other perspectives. Reported separately.

NOT ADAPTIVE

Everyone gets the same form

Unlike the digital SAT, the ACT doesn't change based on your answers. Depending on your test center, you'll take it on paper or on a computer, with the same content either way.

UNSCORED QUESTIONS

Some questions are field tests

ACT mixes unscored field-test questions into each section: about 20% in English, 9% in Math, 25% in Reading and 15% in Science. You can't spot them, so answer everything.

How to use this guide

Just starting?

Read pages 2–6, take ACT's free official practice test, then follow the 12-week roadmap on page 8.

Mid-prep?

Study the traps on page 7 and drill the categories you miss most on pages 3–6.

Test in weeks?

Do the 10 questions on page 9 in 12 minutes, then use the final-four-weeks plan on page 8.



Pigo's tip: There's no penalty for guessing on the ACT. Before time is called, every question should have an answer.

SECTION 1

02 The English section

50 questions in 35 minutes. You'll see passages with underlined parts and choose the best version, or NO CHANGE if the original is already right.

50
questions

~42 sec
per question

4
choices, including NO
CHANGE

0
points lost for a wrong
answer

How the questions are split

ACT's reporting categories for the enhanced English test. Bars show the share of questions, minimum to maximum.

Production of Writing

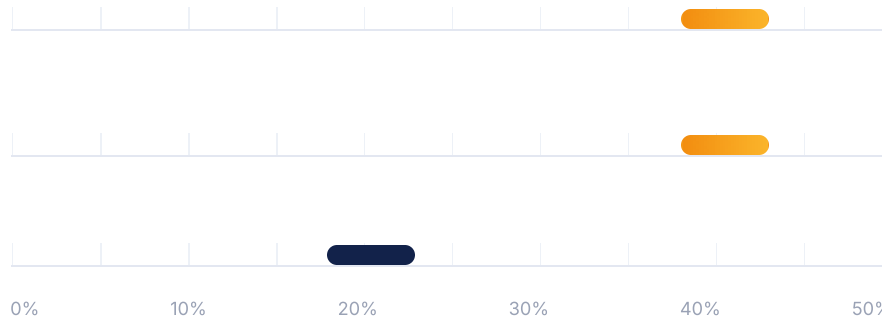
Development, organization,
transitions

Conventions of Standard English

Punctuation, grammar, sentence
structure

Knowledge of Language

Precise, concise, consistent style



38–43%

38–43%

18–23%

Production of Writing

Decide whether to add, delete or move a sentence, pick the transition that fits, and choose the best introduction or conclusion for a paragraph.

Conventions

Commas, semicolons, colons and dashes; subject-verb and pronoun agreement; verb tense; modifiers; run-ons and fragments.

Knowledge of Language

Cut wordiness and redundancy, choose the most precise word, and keep the tone consistent with the passage.

Strategies that work on this section

- NO CHANGE is a real answer.** Pick it when the original is already correct. Don't avoid it just because it feels too easy.
- Shorter is usually better.** When every choice is grammatical, the most concise one that keeps the meaning usually wins.
- Read the whole sentence.** The error is often caused by words outside the underlined part.
- Yes/No first, reason second.** On "should the writer add this?" questions, decide yes or no, then pick the reason that matches the paragraph's focus.
- Compare the choices.** What changes between them (a comma, a verb, a word) tells you what's being tested.
- Keep the pace.** At 42 seconds a question you'll finish with a few minutes to check flagged items.



Pigo's tip: If two choices mean the same thing and are both correct, neither can be the answer. Look for the one that's different.

SECTION 2

03 The Math section

45 questions in 50 minutes, a little over a minute each. You can use a permitted calculator throughout, and there's no formula sheet.

45

questions

~67 sec

per question

4

answer choices (was 5)

0

formulas given, so memorize them

● How the questions are split

About 80% of questions are "Preparing for Higher Math" (the first five rows); the rest are "Integrating Essential Skills".

Algebra

Equations, inequalities, systems

Functions

Notation, graphs, transformations

Geometry

Shapes, coordinate geometry, trig

Statistics & Probability

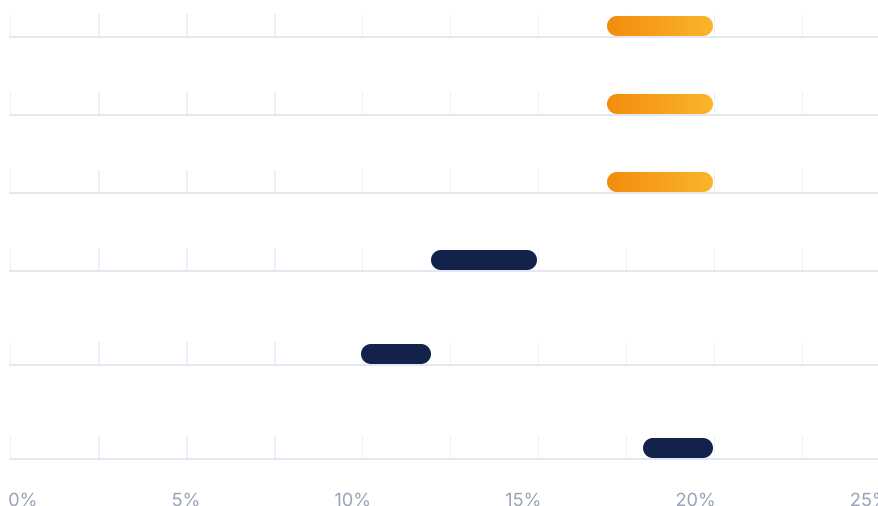
Data, center, spread, chance

Number & Quantity

Exponents, radicals, complex numbers

Integrating Essential Skills

Rates, percents, proportions



17-20%

17-20%

17-20%

12-15%

10-12%

~20%

Modeling counts too. At least 20% of questions are also tagged **Modeling**: you'll build or interpret a math model of a real situation, like a cost function or a growth rate.

NO FORMULA SHEET

Memorize these before test day

- Area: circle πr^2 , triangle $\frac{1}{2}bh$, trapezoid $\frac{1}{2}(b_1 + b_2)h$
- Pythagorean theorem; 30-60-90 and 45-45-90 triangles
- SOH-CAH-TOA; $\sin^2\theta + \cos^2\theta = 1$
- Slope, midpoint and distance formulas
- Quadratic formula and the discriminant
- Log rules: $\log(ab) = \log a + \log b$; $\log_b x = y \Leftrightarrow b^y = x$
- Interior angles of a polygon: $(n - 2) \times 180^\circ$

CALCULATOR POLICY

Check yours before test day

Most graphing and scientific calculators are allowed. Models with a built-in computer algebra system, such as the TI-89 or TI-Nspire CAS, are **not**. Bring fresh batteries, and know whether your calculator is in degree or radian mode.

● Strategies that work on this section

- **Easy points first.** Every question is worth the same. Skip a time sink and come back.
- **Plug in the choices.** With four options, back-solving from the middle value is often the fastest route.
- **Draw the figure.** Sketch geometry and coordinate questions, even when a figure isn't given.
- **Save 3 minutes to guess.** Make sure every question has an answer before time is called.

SECTION 3

04 The Reading section

36 questions in 40 minutes, about 67 seconds per question. Passages are long, so your reading method matters as much as your speed.

36

questions

~67 sec

per question

~10 min

per passage set, including reading

1

paired-passage set

How the questions are split

Key Ideas & Details

Main idea, details, inference, sequence

44–52%

Craft & Structure

Word meaning, purpose, point of view

26–33%

Integration of Knowledge & Ideas

Arguments, paired passages, data

19–26%

0% 15% 30% 45% 60%

The four passage types

Passage	What it's like	How to read it
Literary Narrative	Fiction or memoir; characters, relationships, tone	Track who feels what and how it changes
Social Science	History, economics, psychology, education	Find the argument and the evidence for it
Humanities	Art, music, philosophy, personal essays	Note the author's opinion and attitude words
Natural Science	Biology, physics, earth science research	Map the process or experiment step by step

Strategies that work on this section

- Read actively, once.** Spend about 3 minutes per passage and jot a 3–5 word summary of each paragraph.
- Answer in your own words first.** Then pick the choice that matches. This beats reading four tempting choices cold.
- Go back to the lines.** For line-reference questions, read a few lines before and after the reference.
- Choose your order.** Start with your strongest passage type. You can move between passages within the section.
- Cut extreme and out-of-scope choices.** If a choice says more than the passage does, it's wrong.
- Paired passages:** do the questions on Passage A, then Passage B, then the questions about both.



Pigo's tip: The answer is always in the passage. If you can't point to the line that proves it, keep looking.

05 OPTIONAL SECTIONS

Science & Writing

Neither counts toward your Composite. Take Science if your colleges or programs want a STEM score; take Writing if a college on your list requires or recommends it.

● Science: 40 questions, 40 minutes

Interpretation of Data

Read graphs and tables



36–47%

Scientific Investigation

Design, variables, controls



17–31%

Evaluation of Models

Hypotheses, conclusions



22–36%

0% 25% 50%

- **Data Representation:** one or more graphs or tables to interpret.
- **Research Summaries:** a set of related experiments with results.
- **Conflicting Viewpoints:** two or more scientists explain the same thing differently.

● Science strategies

- **Question first, figure second.** Most questions point to one table or graph; read only what you need.
- **Check axes and units** before reading any value.
- **Find the variables.** What did the scientist change (independent), and what did they measure (dependent)?
- **You need little outside science.** The answer is almost always in the figures and text.
- **Viewpoints:** summarize each scientist in one line before you look at the questions.

STEM SCORE

Your Math and Science scores are averaged into a STEM score, reported only if you take Science.

● Writing: one essay, 40 minutes, scored 2–12

Ideas & Analysis

A clear position that engages with the perspectives given.

Development & Support

Reasons and specific examples that explain your thinking.

Organization

A logical structure with purposeful transitions.

Language Use

Clear, varied sentences with few errors.

A five-paragraph plan that works

- **5 min:** plan your thesis and two reasons
- **Intro:** state your position clearly
- **Body 1–2:** one reason each, with a concrete example
- **Body 3:** answer the strongest opposing view
- **Conclusion + 3 min:** sum up, then proofread

SHOULD YOU TAKE THEM?

Check your college list

Many colleges don't require either, but some STEM programs and scholarships look at the STEM score, and a few colleges still want the essay. When unsure, taking Science keeps your options open.

06

LEARN FROM OTHERS

10 traps that cost points

Meet **Glitch**. He lives in these ten mistakes. Squash each one before test day.

Calculator in radians?
I'll take that point!



01 Avoiding NO CHANGE

It's correct as often as the other choices when the original is fine. Judge the sentence, not the odds.

02 Picking the longest answer

Wordy, redundant choices are usually wrong on English. Concise and clear wins.

03 Comma splices

Two complete sentences joined by just a comma are always wrong. Use a period, semicolon, or comma + FANBOYS.

04 Keeping interesting sentences

On add/delete questions, relevance to the paragraph matters, not whether the fact is interesting.

05 One question, three minutes

Every Math question counts the same. Skip the time sink and come back.

06 Forgetting formulas

There's no reference sheet. If you can't recall the area of a trapezoid, you lose the point.

07 Wrong calculator mode

Degrees vs radians changes every trig answer. Check your mode before the section starts.

08 Rereading whole passages

Reading questions reward finding the right lines, not memorizing the passage.

09 Using outside science

If your knowledge disagrees with the passage's data, go with the data.

10 Running out without guessing

No penalty for wrong answers. Fill in every question before time is called.

Quick self-check: If $\tan \theta = 3/4$ and θ is acute, what is $\sin \theta$? (Answer: $3/5$. Draw a 3-4-5 right triangle: opposite 3, adjacent 4, hypotenuse 5.)

07 PLAN YOUR PREP Your 12-week study roadmap

A steady plan beats cramming. Three or four focused sessions a week is enough for most students, as long as every session ends with reviewing mistakes.

- Week 1**
Baseline
 - **Baseline test** Full test
Take ACT's free official practice test with real timing. Log every miss by section and category in a mistake journal.
- Weeks 2–4**
Foundations
 - **English rules and core math**
Punctuation and grammar rules, plus algebra and functions. Memorize the formula list on page 4.
- Weeks 5–7**
Core skills
 - **Reading method and geometry**
Practice the active-reading method on one passage a day. Geometry, trig and statistics. One timed section each weekend.
- Week 8**
Checkpoint
 - **Second full test** Full test
Compare each section with Week 1 and re-aim the last month at what's still weakest.
- Weeks 9–10**
Speed
 - **Pacing and Science**
Timed sections only. Add Science practice if you're taking it, and one Writing essay if you need it.
- Weeks 11–12**
Test mode
 - **Full tests and review** Full test
Two more full tests on Saturday mornings. Review every miss, then go light in the last two days.

● The final four weeks

Week	Focus	Target
4 weeks out	Full practice test, then review every miss by category	Name your three weakest areas
3 weeks out	Drill those areas; one timed section a day	Finish each section on time
2 weeks out	Full practice test at 8 a.m. with the real breaks	Beat your Week 8 Composite
Final week	Light review of grammar rules and formulas; print your admission ticket	Rest the night before

Plan to take it twice. Most colleges superscore the ACT, so a first test in the fall or winter and a retake in the spring gives you two chances at each section.

08 TEST YOURSELF 10 practice questions

Original, ACT-style and pitched hard. For 1–3, choose the best version of the underlined part. Calculator OK on 4–7. Allow 12 minutes.

1 ENGLISH · AGREEMENT

The museum's new exhibit, which features more than two hundred photographs from the 1930s, are drawing record crowds every weekend.

- A** NO CHANGE **B** is drawing
C have drawn **D** were drawing

2 ENGLISH · PUNCTUATION

Marine biologists have studied the octopus for decades, its ability to change color in milliseconds still surprises them.

- F** NO CHANGE **G** decades; its
H decades its **J** decades, it's

3 ENGLISH · CONCISION

The final vote of the club members was completely and totally unanimous, with every member voting yes.

- A** NO CHANGE **B** unanimous
C unanimous, all in agreement **D** totally unanimous in agreement

4 MATH · ALGEBRA

What is the sum of all solutions to $|2x - 5| = 9$?

- F** 2 **G** 5 **H** 7 **J** 9

5 MATH · FUNCTIONS

If $f(x) = 3x - 2$ and $g(x) = x^2 + 1$, what is $f(g(2))$?

- A** 13 **B** 15 **C** 17 **D** 25

6 MATH · STATISTICS

The mean of five numbers is 12. When one number is removed, the mean of the remaining four is 10. What number was removed?

- F** 2 **G** 10 **H** 12 **J** 20

7 MATH · GEOMETRY

What is the radius of the circle $x^2 + y^2 - 6x + 8y = 0$?

- A** 4 **B** 5 **C** 10 **D** 25

8 READING · MAIN IDEA

Many early American libraries were funded by subscription: members paid a yearly fee to borrow books. Reformers argued that this model shut out exactly the readers who stood to gain the most. A free library, they insisted, was not a charity but an investment, as essential to a town as its schools. By the early 1900s that argument had largely won, helped by donors such as Andrew Carnegie, who paid for library buildings on the condition that towns pay to run them.

The main purpose of the passage is to:

- F** argue that subscription libraries had better book collections. **G** describe a shift in how libraries were funded and the reasoning behind it.
H explain why Andrew Carnegie began donating money to libraries. **J** compare American libraries with libraries in Europe.

9 SCIENCE · INTERPRETING DATA

Ramp angle (°)	10	20	30	40
Roll time for 50 g ball (s)	2.9	2.1	1.7	1.5

Based on the table, if the ramp were set at 25°, the roll time would most likely be:

- A** less than 1.5 s **B** between 1.5 s and 1.7 s
C between 1.7 s and 2.1 s **D** greater than 2.1 s

10 SCIENCE · INVESTIGATION

The student repeats the 40° trial with a 100 g ball and again measures 1.5 s. This result best supports which claim?

- F** Mass strongly affects roll time.
G Mass has little or no effect on roll time at 40°.
H Increasing the angle increases roll time.
J The ramp was longer in the second trial.

09

CHECK YOUR WORK

Answer key & explanations

Read every explanation, even for questions you got right. Each one points to a pattern that keeps coming back on the test.

#	Answer	Why
1	B	The subject is exhibit , which is singular. Skip the clause between the commas: the exhibit is drawing .
2	G	Both halves are complete sentences, so the comma creates a splice. A semicolon fixes it. J also uses <i>it's</i> (it is) instead of the possessive <i>its</i> .
3	B	"Unanimous" already means everyone agreed, so "completely," "totally" and "all in agreement" are redundant.
4	G	$2x - 5 = 9$ gives $x = 7$, and $2x - 5 = -9$ gives $x = -2$. The sum is $7 + (-2) = 5$.
5	A	Work inside out: $g(2) = 5$, then $f(5) = 13$. Choice C (17) is $g(f(2))$, the trap for doing it in the wrong order.
6	J	Total of five numbers = $5 \times 12 = 60$. Total of four = $4 \times 10 = 40$. The removed number is $60 - 40 = 20$.
7	B	Complete the square: $(x - 3)^2 + (y + 4)^2 = 9 + 16 = 25$, so the radius is $\sqrt{25} = 5$. Choice D is r^2 , not r .
8	G	The passage moves from subscription libraries to the case for free ones and how that case won. Carnegie is one detail, not the purpose.
9	C	25° is between 20° (2.1 s) and 30° (1.7 s), and roll time falls steadily as the angle rises, so the time is between 1.7 and 2.1 s.
10	G	Doubling the mass left the time unchanged at 1.5 s, so mass had little or no effect. Only one variable changed, so H and J aren't supported.

What your score tells you

9–10

Strong. Move on to full-length timed practice tests.

6–8

On track. Revisit the section behind every miss on pages 3–6.

0–5

Build foundations. Start with grammar rules and algebra before you time yourself.



Pigo's tip: Notice the letters: ACT alternates A–D and F–J so you don't bubble in the wrong row. Use that as a check.

10

KNOW THE TARGET

Scores & 2026–27 test dates

Each section is scored from 1 to 36. Your Composite is the average of English, Math and Reading, rounded to the nearest whole number.

19.4

national average Composite, class of 2025

1.4M

2025 graduates took the ACT, about 36% of the class

30%

of ACT-tested 2025 grads met at least 3 college-readiness benchmarks

2–12

Writing score, reported separately

• How your scores are built

Score	Scale	How it's calculated
Composite	1–36	Average of English, Math and Reading. Science is no longer included.
Superscore	1–36	Average of your best English, Math and Reading scores from any test dates. Many colleges use it.
STEM	1–36	Average of Math and Science. Reported only if you take Science.
Writing	2–12	Two readers score four domains; reported on its own.

Set your own target from your college list. Look up each college's middle-50% ACT range (in its Common Data Set, section C9, or admissions page) and aim for the upper half.

• 2026–27 ACT national test dates

Test date	Register by	Good for
October 17, 2026	Registration closed	Seniors applying early
December 12, 2026	November 6	Regular-decision seniors; juniors' first try
February 27, 2027	January 22	Juniors after winter prep
April 10, 2027	March 5	Juniors before AP season
June 12, 2027	May 7	Juniors' retake after school ends
July 10, 2027	June 4	Rising seniors with a summer of prep

Late registration is available for a fee on most dates. Dates as published for 2026–27; always confirm on act.org before you register. Many states and districts also offer the ACT free on a school day.

YOUR TOOLKIT

11

Free resources & test-day checklist

Official material is the best practice there is, because it's written by the people who write the test.

1

Official ACT practice test **FREE**

act.org

ACT's free full-length practice test for the enhanced format, with answers and a scoring table. Your Week 1 baseline.

2

The Official ACT Prep Guide

Latest edition, from ACT

Several real past tests with explanations. The best paid resource if you want more official practice.

3

MyACT account **FREE**

my.act.org

Register, choose score recipients, view scores and order Test Information Release when it's offered.

4

Khan Academy **FREE**

khanacademy.org

Free lessons on algebra, geometry, trigonometry and grammar to fill gaps found by your practice tests.

5

ACT calculator policy **FREE**

act.org

The list of prohibited calculators. Check yours well before test day.

6

ACT SAT GO free practice tests **FREE**

actsatgo.com

Timed practice tests with a score report, plus a free diagnostic lesson with a tutor.

• Test-day checklist

- ☐ Printed admission ticket from MyACT
- ☐ Acceptable photo ID
- ☐ Sharpened No. 2 pencils with erasers (no mechanical pencils)
- ☐ Permitted calculator with fresh batteries, set to the right mode
- ☐ A watch without an alarm (no smartwatches)
- ☐ Snack and water for the break
- ☐ Arrive by 8:00 a.m. check-in
- ☐ Phone off and put away for the whole test
- ☐ Know which optional sections you registered for
- ☐ A good night's sleep. No new material the night before.

Testing with accommodations? Request them through your school when you register, well before the deadline. Decisions can take several weeks.



Pigo's tip: Do your last full practice test at 8 a.m. on a Saturday. Your brain will know the routine on test day.

ACT SAT GO • 1-ON-1 ACT TUTORING

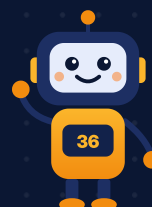
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Book a free diagnostic lesson. We'll find your weakest sections, review your practice tests, and give you a week-by-week plan to test day.

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